

AGE OF MYTHOS

Central — Chapter 1 — Rise of Legends

Central · Madhya · English Edition

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Dandakaranya — Blood And Iron

Chhattisgarh's forests are ancient beyond measure. The Dandakaranya — the Punished Forest of Ramayana fame, where Rama wandered in exile — stretches across the state like a green lung breathing for the entire subcontinent. The tribal people of Bastar have lived here since before history began keeping records, and their relationship with the forest is not stewardship — it is kinship.

Dandakarni was found at the forest's edge by a Gond tribal family. She was perhaps two years old, covered in mud, sitting among wild buffalo calves with the calm expression of a child who has been exactly where she belongs. No one knew where she came from. The tribal elders said the forest had made her. Looking at how she fights — with the raw, unstoppable fury of a wild buffalo charge — they may be right.

The wild buffalo tattoo appeared on her chest the first time she defended the forest. Miners had come with machines and documents, and the tribal leaders had signed papers they could not read. Dandakarni did not sign anything. She charged the lead excavator, war hammer swinging, and the impact crumpled the machine's arm like paper. She was sixteen.

Loh-Rakshasa took notice. Here was a force that could not be bought, reasoned with, or ignored. He came to the forest himself — a massive man with his excavator-arm grafted to his right shoulder, walking through the trees like a monster from the industrial age invading the age of nature.

Their first battle — at the edge of the Indravati River — lasted eleven hours. The earth itself seemed to take sides: where Dandakarni stood, roots rose to trip the Iron Demon. Where Loh-Rakshasa walked, iron ore burst from the ground like teeth. The river ran red — not with blood, but with iron oxide disturbed from the riverbed.

Her brother — her actual brother, blood-kin, raised in the same tribal village — defected to Loh-Rakshasa's side, believing that mining could bring prosperity to the impoverished tribals. They have fought twice since then. Both times ended in draws, because neither sibling can bring themselves to deliver the final blow.

The Hill Mynas of Chhattisgarh have been repeating a single phrase throughout the forest, a phrase they heard from Vanvasi Mata: "The iron in your blood is the same iron in the

earth." No one knows if the mynas understand what they're saying. But the forest listens, and the wild buffalo raise their heads when they hear it, and the tribal drums beat a rhythm that sounds like a heartbeat — the heartbeat of a forest that refuses to be mined.

Dandakarni's war hammer rings against Loh-Rakshasa's iron arm, and the sound echoes through the Dandakaranya like the forest's own war cry. The trees lean toward the sound. They are listening.

They have been listening for millennia. And they are not patient anymore.

Hridaya Sthana — The Twelve Move War

Madhya Pradesh is the heart of India — geographically, historically, and strategically. Control the center and you control the continent. Lose the center and the edges tear themselves apart. Dvadashashringa understands this with every fiber of his being, because the barasingha — the twelve-antlered deer that gives him his name — is the king of the swamp, and the swamp is the center of the forest.

His twelve-pronged staff is not merely a weapon — it is a calculating machine. Each prong represents a strategic principle: patience, misdirection, sacrifice, encirclement, retreat, advance, alliance, betrayal-prevention, supply, morale, terrain, and timing. In battle, he rotates the staff so that the relevant prong faces forward, announcing his current strategy to those who can read the language of war.

Naimisha-Naag does not fight with weapons. He fights with words, and his words are more devastating than any blade.

The first time Dvadashashringa faced the Serpent, it was not in battle but in conversation. The Naag appeared at the edge of the Naimisharanya forest — a shimmering, enormous serpent with a human voice that carried the cadence of every story ever told.

"You are a chess master," the Serpent said. "Tell me — what is the point of winning a game?"

"To protect what you value," Dvadashashringa replied.

"And what do you value?"

"My kingdom. My people. The center."

"And when you die, what happens to your kingdom, your people, your center?"

"Someone else protects them."

"And when they die?"

Dvadashashringa felt the first breath of the Serpent's venom — not in his body but in his mind. Doubt. The recognition that every kingdom falls, every center collapses, every chess game ends. The Mahabharata's heroes won — and then they all died, and then everything they built crumbled.

The Asian Paradise Flycatcher — the white-tailed bird of extraordinary grace — landed on Dvadashashringa's shoulder and sang a note so pure that the doubt shattered like glass.

The bird sees beauty in everything. Where the Serpent sees futility in the cycle of rise-and-fall, the Flycatcher sees beauty. The hero rises not because it lasts, but because it is beautiful to rise.

Dvadashashringa understood. He cannot defeat the Serpent with logic — the Serpent's logic is flawless. He can only defeat it with purpose: the decision that some things are worth doing even though they end.

The war between them is fought in the Naimisharanya forest, where the Mahabharata was first spoken. It is a war of words, moves, and counter-moves — a chess game played with ideas instead of pieces. Dvadashashringa moves twelve moves ahead. The Serpent whispers: "And after the twelfth move, what then?"

The Bhimbetka cave paintings, 30,000 years old, show this exact scene: a twelve-antlered deer facing a serpent in a forest. The Rishi says the painting shows who wins.

He has not said who.